Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort to have a pretty and perfect picture, yellow often appears when we want to **light** something up, **think** something up or simply **breathe out**.

In free painting there is no need to know in advance what you are expressing. First **you can** paint. Meaning may appear later — and sometimes it does not appear at all.

What may be hiding behind a yellow stroke

The same yellow line on paper can mean **something completely different every time** – depending on what is going on in us at the moment. Sometimes it is **joy**, sometimes **restlessness**, sometimes the pure taste of the colour. That is why there is no point in reading a painting like a test with **a single correct answer**.

Joy and lightness

Small light strokes, sparks, rays running out from one place. The paper is light and spacious.

Ideas and flashes

Zigzags, stars, short punchy strokes. Like when something occurs to you that you want to capture at once.

Confidence and being seen

A large bright area in the middle of the paper, a sun that has nothing against shining.

Overload and nervousness

Lots of yellow strokes over one another, sharp edges, sometimes with black. The head running at full power.

Bitterness and envy

A sour, greenish yellow, narrow strokes pushing towards something. When you feel sorry about something and do not want to admit it.

Tiredness and fading

A pale, washed-out yellow, a stroke that disappears at the end. A colour in which there is almost no sun left.

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Yellow in a painting. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it can – but it does not have to. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Yellow can then give form to **joy**, to ideas and a longing for light, but also to a feeling that you have to be cheerful all the time.

Equally it can simply be a pretty colour that you happened to have to hand that day. Meaning comes only in connection with your experience. **The colour itself does not know what happened to you**. You do – or you will work it out in time.

Art therapy also works with the idea that a picture can express something for which words are hard to find. What matters is not a single patch of colour but **the whole picture** and how it came to be. Your situation, memories, the movement of your hand and your feelings while painting.

A predominance of yellow alone is not enough for a verdict on whether it is **joy** or the need to be cheerful. Perhaps you were in a good mood. Perhaps you wanted to light up a grey sheet of paper. And perhaps you simply enjoyed that yellow so much that grey had no chance that day.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A yellow painting and a yellow jumper may ask two completely different things of you. On canvas you give space to experience. In clothing **you may** feel that you are visible and that cheerfulness is expected of you. That is why a large yellow area in a painting can attract you while the thought of walking out among people in a yellow coat frightens you.

That is entirely fine. In creating, **you can** thus more easily try out a boldness you do not yet want to wear on your body. No obligatory wardrobe makeover has to follow. Perhaps it is enough for you that this part of you has a place on the canvas.

Only later **you may** notice whether you are tempted to carry a bit of that experience into life. For example through earrings, a yellow scarf or a flower on the table.

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When yellow takes over the space

First let the hand work. **You do not have to paint joy** or a little sun. Yellow can quite well be a large unnamed area. The interpretation can wait and you do not have to choose the right reason before you touch the canvas.

Three things worth noticing

QUANTITY

A small trace, or a large area?

How much space yellow gets today. A small yellow trace in the middle of a large area can be more important to you than a whole yellow painting. It may recall something precious, fragile, distant or newly emerging. A large area can be pleasantly full, warm and free, but it can also start to feel too insistent. A lot of yellow does not automatically mean a lot of joy, and a little yellow does not mean a lack of life force.

SATURATION

A sharp lemon, or butter?

A striking yellow may be exactly what you want today. A bright trace that does not get lost. At other times a yellow with white, an ochre or a mix that no longer has such a sharp look will feel better. If relief appears after you add white, that very change may be important to you. Not as a rule “I needed less energy”, but as a specific realisation “This feels closer to me today.”

THICKNESS

Thick, or translucent?

Thick paint offers a different resistance when you work than thin. You may enjoy its body, coverage and the trace of the hand or tool. You may want to press, layer and feel that something is really coming into being under your hands. A translucent yellow offers a different experience. The ground shows through, colours overlap and individual layers remain visible. Neither is a personality test. A thick layer alone does not mean accumulated anger and a translucent colour does not mean insecurity.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter how the yellow stroke looks. **What matters is what you feel while making it**, what situation you are in and what is happening in your life right now. Two identical paintings can have a completely different meaning. One came from an idea that lit you up, the other after a day when you tried to stay positive all the time. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but questions.

When the painting speaks only later

After finishing **you may** feel **relief**, **satisfaction**, tiredness or nothing special at all. Sometimes you only notice after several days that the yellow area attracts you differently. You can return to the painting in a different state of mind.

What to take from the picture

Looking back later **you can** connect the painting with what was happening then. You may recall, for example, that for the first time in a long while you painted without trying to please anyone. Or that yellow, on the contrary, irritated you and a blue area brought **relief**.

This way of self-reflection is inspired by work with experience in art therapy. You look for meaning in your experience, not in a table that would assign the same translation to every yellow stroke.

You can try a favourite combination outside the painting too. First on fabrics, clothing or a small object. A canvas is not an order to repaint the kitchen.

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